

St Isacc the Syrian teaches principles of fighting lust and all bodily sins

A letter from Priest Seraphim. Feb 1. 2023 ns

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"IT IS NOT POSSIBLE to vanquish evil thoughts that are joined to bodily incitements, or rather, it is very difficult. They are called by some a two-edged sword used against us. There can be no rest from them as long as there is satiety in bread, water, and sleep, and we have access to things that can provoke us through the senses. Cessation of life is better than the shame of these things. When we are diligent in that which it befits us to do, the influence of the flesh will abate in our members.

"It is not possible both to be solicitous over the things of the senses and to set aright our passions. Without fervent supplications and continual prostrations, it is impossible to draw God's mercies toward us; and it is necessary for us always to continue practicing both one and the other. Without painstaking in small matters, it is impossible to escape from great evils."

ST ISAAC THE SYRIAN, Ascetical Homilies, HOMILY Thirty-three, "That in Certain Conflicts Labor Is Better Than Being in Danger of Falling."

To understand the words of the Saint, we must understand several things. First of all, we must understand: *what are evil thoughts?*

The world knows nothing of evil thoughts. The world accepts many evil thoughts as good. Pride, vanity, lust, gluttony, and judging others, are all thoughts the world readily accepts. Another evil thought is that most people consider their entertainment and their pleasure a priority.

Another terrible evil thought, or rather a disposition, is to take as our teachers the ways of the world rather than the mind of the church. This is a very common and pernicious thought. This is why people can change their opinions like the waves of the sea.

Let us apply the words of the Saint to pernicious addictions that affect many, including even those that would like to call themselves Christians. These are the temptations of lust, and its incarnation in various forms, pornography, self-abuse, fornication, drug abuse, addictions to social media, and video games.

Yes, drug abuse and other addictions are a type of lust because they are an unholy desire for something which the soul innately knows is forbidden. Certainly, some will argue with me about video games, and it is possible to play a little bit of some video games. But those who play them until they are fully dissipated and exhausted and go to sleep without prayer are addicted, and something in their soul realizes this, although consciously they may deny that their addiction to games is pernicious.

Do you know how to determine if a desire of yours is good or bad and that the fulfillment of that desire is good or bad? When your soul is still tender and still can discern right and wrong, if you feel dissipated by something, it is bad. If you feel you have wasted your time or are filled with shame after what you have done with your mind or your body, it is toxic to your soul and is a sin.

When you are aware that you have sinned and that something is inherently toxic to your soul, you must act quickly. If you do not, eventually your soul will

become hardened and calloused, and you will not think that the thing that you do is wrong, or there will be just a dull ache inside you, but no energy to combat the sin, and you will continue it to the end of your days and go to Hell.

The modern man is not different in nature from ancient man, but he is different in his environment, which caters to his laziness, gluttony, and his lust.

Let's be more specific about the advice of the saint. If you do not fast, you will never overcome, or perhaps, as the saint says, only overcome with very great difficulty, masturbation and the addiction to pornography. And if you continually take your ease by inundating your mind with social media, television, and indulgence of the flesh via laziness, you will not overcome any passion of the flesh.

The cure for the passions of lust, and the prison of pornography, drug abuse, and the common ennui and directionless and purposelessness in modern life is only attained through labor. That labor must include fasting, prayer, prayer with prostrations, and bodily activity. If a person spends useless hours late at night doing useless things and then does not rise in the morning early enough to say prayers with prostrations, they will likely never overcome these bodily enticements.

The world tells us that self-indulgence is a good thing or at least a neutral thing. The soul knows better, but the words of the world overpower the lethargic soul. If you are held captive by pornography, masturbation, smoking marijuana (which is toxic to the soul no matter what the world tells you), mindless scrolling on the internet, video games for hours upon hours etc., you must become active. You must shake off the lie that your soul tells you that these things are not so bad or that you can never overcome them, so why should you try? You must shake off the whispering

in your ear that tells you the prostrations are hard, and saying the Akathist is difficult, and besides you haven't really changed when you've done these things, so why continue?

You're not fighting against pornography and masturbation and intoxication. You are fighting for your very soul not to fall into the depths of Hell. If you were aware that within 5 minutes, someone would be breaking down your door to kill everyone in your home, you would stand up and be ready to fight. This is what is happening to your soul, and you are lying down and allowing the barbarians to come in and decimate you. You are actually doing more than this! You are inviting them in to kill you.

Get active! Do something! Always react with repentance when you indulge yourself. If you eat too much, then when you are able, do some prostrations. When you look at pornography you must say prayers afterward. When you smoke marijuana or indulge in video games for a mindless period of time, you must consider it to be as toxic as pornography, masturbation or fornication (and say prayers of repentance afterward, such as the "Prayers for Purity," or simply doing some prostrations and asking for forgiveness).

There are some that will react to my words by taking offense. If you want to play video games and you can do them for a few minutes, then you are not addicted, but if you play them all night and are dissipated, then they are a pathway for you to hell. It is not possible to smoke marijuana a little bit. It is not possible to indulge in sexual perversion a little bit. And let's be honest. Those who engage in indulging themselves in pornography are always watching sexual perversion. It is a rare person who watches pornography that is only naked people. It is naked people doing unspeakable things, unnatural things that are forbidden on the marriage bed. Therefore, the

person who looks at pornography is usually guilty of adultery, fornication, sodomy, and self abuse.

The words of St. Isaac are frightening to those of us who are lazy and addicted. But they also should be encouraging to us. At the end of his words, he says: "Without painstaking in small matters, it is impossible to escape from great evils." It is better to do a little thing than *not* do a big thing. Let's be painstaking in doing something that is a small matter.

Of course, it is better that we give up our addictions and we have purity in our hearts and our bodies. But even if we cannot do this, we can do something. Begin by doing something. Begin by always reacting in some way to your sins, even if it is only by making the sign of the cross and saying "Lord forgive me for my sin", or making one prostration. Eventually, that one prostration will become 3, and then 12, then 100, and that sign of the cross will become attentive prayer. And as you become stronger, you become more confident. And you will conquer your sin.

Priest Seraphim Holland , St. Nicholas Orthodox Church, McKinney Texas

seraphim@orthodox.net

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